

Sabor sang Panahon

Game Design Document

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Platform: PC / Windows

Engine: Godot 4.7

Genre: First-person 3D narrative exploration, mystery, cultural heritage game

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1. Overview

One-Sentence Pitch

Sabor sang Panahon is a first-person 3D cultural mystery game where a hungry player returns to La Paz, Iloilo to reconstruct a forgotten dish through elder memories, Cultural Echoes, AI-driven artifact placement, and a timed search for the Memory Bowl before Grandma comes home for dinner.

Target Audience

- Ages 13+
- Filipino students and young players

- Casual narrative game players
- Players interested in culture, food, and local history
- Educational and heritage-focused audiences

Platforms

- Primary: PC / Windows
- Possible future platform: Web or Android, depending on performance and scope

Player Fantasy

The player becomes a cultural memory detective: walking through La Paz, listening to elders, following sounds of memory, collecting ingredients, and recovering a dish that connects family, place, and Ilonggo identity.

Design Pillars

1. **Food as Memory**
The lost dish is not only a recipe. It represents family, place, and cultural identity.
2. **Discovery Through Local Stories**
NPC testimonies, old objects, and neighborhood details guide the player toward the truth.
3. **AI-Driven Artifact Placement**
The final heritage artifact is placed through an AI-assisted placement system, while AMBot presents the results through an in-world assistant interface.
4. **Sound-Guided Exploration**
Players follow Cultural Echoes such as boiling broth, bowls clinking, market chatter, and Hiligaynon voices.
5. **Personal Emotional Stakes**
The goal is not just to solve a mystery, but to cook the recovered dish for Grandma before she returns for dinner.

Non-Goals

- No combat system
 - No multiplayer
 - No full open-world recreation of Iloilo
 - No complex economy or resource grinding
 - No in-game permanent digital museum, since the official Game Portal handles artifact storage
 - No advanced cooking simulator beyond simple interactive preparation
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2. Core Gameplay

Core Loop

Wake up hungry → search apartment → find damaged newspaper → activate AMBot → ride jeepney to La Paz → talk to Grandma → explore La Paz on foot → interview residents → collect clues and ingredients → follow Cultural Echoes → artifact placement system determines the Memory Bowl location → AMBot runs out of tokens → return to old house → find the Memory Bowl → trigger Game Portal submission → cook Batchoy → Grandma remembers.

Controls Summary

- WASD: Move
- Mouse: Look
- E: Interact, inspect, talk, collect
- Shift: Sprint or fast walk
- Tab / M: Open AMBot map and evidence tracker
- Esc: Pause menu

Win Condition

The player wins by finding all required ingredients, discovering the Memory Bowl, triggering the official Game Portal API submission, cooking La Paz Batchoy, and serving it to Grandma before dinner.

Failure State

During the final timed search, if Grandma returns before the player finds the Memory Bowl and completes the dish, the game restarts at the start of the final Memory Bowl search. The player does not replay the entire game.

Game Modes

- **Story Mode:** Main intended experience.
 - **Prototype / Debug Mode:** Optional development mode for testing artifact placement, clue spawning, and Cultural Echo volumes.
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3. Systems

Movement

The game uses first-person 3D walking exploration. The player rides a jeepney only when traveling from the apartment to La Paz and back. Once in La Paz, all exploration happens on foot.

Progression

Progression is based on:

- NPC conversations
- Collected memory fragments
- Collected ingredients
- AMBot progress prompts and mapping outputs
- Final timed search completion

The game progresses through apartment discovery, La Paz investigation, ingredient recovery, final house search, artifact discovery, and the cooking ending.

Economy

No traditional economy. Optional small interaction tasks may involve helping vendors or completing simple minigames, but money is not a core system.

AI and AMBot

AMBot stands for **Artificial Mapping Bot**. In gameplay, AMBot is a lightweight scripted assistant that acts like an AI through dialogue, map prompts, evidence tracking, and reconstruction messages. It does not need to call a large language model during normal play, which keeps the game fast, affordable, and reliable.

AMBot tracks:

- NPCs talked to
- Districts explored
- Clues found
- Ingredients collected
- Memory fragments unlocked

The actual AI feature is the **procedural heritage artifact placement system**. This system uses AI-assisted logic to choose the Memory Bowl's final location from handcrafted valid spawn zones based on the player's collected evidence, NPC conversations, and explored areas. This keeps the world designed and playable while allowing artifact placement to change between playthroughs.

Difficulty and Balancing Notes

- Artifact placement should vary, but remain believable.
 - Cultural Echoes must be clear enough to guide without becoming direct quest markers.
 - The final timer should create urgency but should not feel unfair.
 - Failure restarts only the final artifact search phase.
 - Optional accessibility settings can reduce timer pressure.
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4. Content

Levels / Maps

Apartment

Opening tutorial area. The player wakes up hungry, searches for food, finds the damaged newspaper, activates AMBot, and discovers the jeepney route map.

Jeepney Transition

A short route selection or travel scene that moves the player from the apartment to La Paz. The jeepney is used only for travel to La Paz and back.

La Paz District

Main exploration area. The player walks through streets, market spaces, food stalls, residential corners, and community areas to talk to NPCs and collect ingredients.

Grandma's Old House

The player's first destination in La Paz and the emotional center of the game. Grandma gives the first hints, leaves to buy medicine, and returns later for dinner. The house later becomes the final timed search area.

Memory Version of the House

Triggered after the Memory Bowl is found. The house briefly transforms into its remembered past: bowls clinking, customers eating, broth boiling, and the old batchoyan coming alive.

Characters

Player

A young Ilonggo who finds an old newspaper and returns to La Paz to uncover a forgotten dish.

Grandmother

Sick and preparing to buy medicine in the afternoon. She cannot remember the dish's name, but gives sensory clues about hot broth, noodles, market life, and familiar smells.

AMBot

Artificial Mapping Bot. A scripted in-world assistant that tracks evidence, displays progress, maps likely search zones, and supports the investigation until it narratively runs out of tokens.

Market Vendor

Provides clues about noodles, broth, ingredients, and market traditions.

Jeepney Driver

Remembers people traveling to La Paz to eat and provides context about routes and community food habits.

Elder Neighbor

Remembers family traditions, rainy afternoons, and smells from old batchoyan spaces.

Teacher / Local Historian

Provides historical context and explains why local food heritage matters.

Items

- Damaged newspaper
- Jeepney route map
- Miki noodles
- Pork broth base
- Pork liver or meat
- Chicharon
- Garlic
- Scallions
- Egg
- Covered signboard
- The Memory Bowl
- Stained recipe note

Narrative Beats

1. Player wakes up hungry in their apartment.
2. Player searches for food and finds a damaged newspaper about an unknown dish from La Paz.
3. AMBot scans the article but cannot identify the dish.

4. Player finds a jeepney route map and travels to La Paz.
 5. Player visits Grandma first at the old house.
 6. Grandma is sick and leaves in the afternoon to buy medicine, returning at dinner.
 7. Player decides to recover and cook the dish for her before she returns.
 8. Player explores La Paz on foot, interviews residents, and collects ingredients.
 9. Cultural Echoes guide the player toward clues.
 10. AMBot helps map search zones while the AI placement system determines the final artifact location.
 11. AMBot runs out of tokens, and the player returns to the old house for the final timed search.
 12. Player reveals the covered sign: “Ted’s Oldtimer La Paz Batchoy” or a fictionalized equivalent.
 13. Player follows intensified Cultural Echoes and finds the Memory Bowl.
 14. Discovery screen appears and the game calls the official Game Portal API.
 15. Player cooks the completed dish.
 16. Grandma returns, tastes it, and remembers: “Batchoy... Amo ni. Amo gid ni ang sabor sang La Paz.”
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5. UX and UI

Player Journey Flow

Main menu → apartment tutorial → newspaper discovery → AMBot activation → jeepney travel → Grandma conversation → La Paz exploration → ingredient collection → AMBot token limit → final timed house search → Memory Bowl discovery → Game Portal submission → cooking scene → ending.

HUD Requirements

- Interaction prompt
- Current objective
- Ingredient checklist
- AMBot map/search zone panel
- Memory fragment tracker
- Cultural Echo visual pulse, optional
- Final phase timer
- Game Portal submission status

Menus

- Main menu
- Pause menu

- Settings
- Controls
- Credits / cultural sources
- AMBot interface:
 - Map
 - Evidence tracker
 - Ingredient tracker
 - Memory fragments
 - Token/status readout

Accessibility

- Subtitles for all dialogue and Cultural Echo voice lines
 - Adjustable mouse sensitivity
 - Volume sliders for music, ambience, voices, and Cultural Echoes
 - Optional visual indicator for audio clues
 - Timer assist or relaxed timer option
 - Interaction highlights for important objects
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6. Production

Milestones

1. Player controller, apartment blackout, and interaction system
2. Newspaper discovery, AMBot UI, and jeepney transition
3. La Paz walking map blackout
4. Grandma scene, NPC dialogue, and clue tracking
5. Ingredient placement and collection system
6. AI integration for procedural artifact placement
7. Cultural Echo audio system
8. Final timer and Memory Bowl search
9. Discovery screen and mock Game Portal API
10. Cooking ending, polish, testing, and submission build

Risks and Unknowns

- Official Game Portal API details are not available yet
- AI placement reliability and fallback behavior
- Balancing randomized placement with handcrafted level design
- Cultural accuracy and permission concerns if using “Ted’s Oldtimer” directly
- 3D asset production time
- Cultural Echo audio clarity

- Timer frustration during the final phase

Dependencies

- Godot 4.7
 - AI-assisted artifact placement module
 - Official Game Portal API after registration
 - 3D assets for apartment, La Paz street, market, old house, signs, and ingredients
 - Audio assets for Cultural Echoes
 - Dialogue writing and cultural references
 - Optional voice acting or generated placeholder voice lines
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7. Marketing and Monetization

Positioning

Sabor sang Panahon is a short Ilonggo cultural heritage mystery about food, family, memory, and AI-assisted artifact discovery. It highlights La Paz Batchoy as a living cultural memory rather than just a dish.

Comparable Games / References

- *Gone Home* for first-person environmental storytelling
- *Venba* for food, family, and cultural memory
- *Season: A Letter to the Future* for collecting memories
- *Outer Wilds* for audio-guided discovery
- *Never Alone* for respectful cultural storytelling

Pricing / Business Model

- Hackathon version: free prototype / competition submission
 - Future version: free educational demo or small indie release, depending on scope, polish, and permissions
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8. Competition Mechanics Compliance

Hidden AI Heritage Artifact

The hidden artifact is **The Memory Bowl**, an old serving bowl wrapped with a stained recipe note inside the player's family house. It is discovered during the final timed search.

AI Placement

The game uses an AI-assisted procedural placement system to choose the Memory Bowl's final hiding place from handcrafted valid spawn zones based on NPC testimonies, explored areas, and collected evidence. AMBot presents this system through in-world map prompts and reconstruction dialogue, but AMBot itself is a scripted assistant rather than a token-consuming AI model.

Cultural Echoes

Players follow adaptive audio clues that become louder and clearer as they approach important items. Examples include boiling broth, bowls clinking, chopping garlic, market chatter, jeepney sounds, and Hiligaynon voices.

Digital Museum / Game Portal

When the Memory Bowl is found, the game immediately shows a custom Discovery Screen and calls the official Game Portal API provided by the organizers. The permanent digital gallery is handled by the official portal, not by the game.

Regional Cultural Heritage

The game centers on La Paz, Iloilo City and the cultural memory of La Paz Batchoy through ingredients, oral history, local movement, family memory, and neighborhood exploration.